Gopala Guru Gosvami

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A Boy at the Lord's Side

Neither the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” nor the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” mentions Gopala Guru Gosvami by name. His memory has been kept alive by the traditions of the Radhakanta Matha in Puri, the house he once headed, by the writings of his followers, and by a song that is sung on the day of his passing. From these his life can be pieced together.

He was born in Orissa into a brahmana family. His father was named Murari Pandita; his mother's name has not come down to us, nor have the years of his life or the day of his appearance. His earlier name was Makaradhvaja Pandita.

While still a child he came to be near Mahaprabhu in Puri and served the Lord under Govinda, His personal servant. From his earliest years he also lived with Vakreshvara Pandita, who cared for him and guided him. Mahaprabhu was especially tender towards him, often joked with him, and affectionately called him “Gopala,” for in the boy's childlike ways He saw Gopala-Krishna Himself. For Gopala, in turn, the whole world was contained in Gauranga. He knew nothing but service to Him, lived for that joy alone, and could not bear to be parted from the Lord even for a moment: Gaura was his very life.

How Gopala Became “Guru”

Tradition tells how the boy came by his second name. There lived in Puri a devotee so attached to the holy name that his tongue kept repeating it ceaselessly, of its own accord. One day Gopala saw him on his way to the latrine holding his tongue with his fingers, so that the Name would not sound in an unclean place. The boy began to set him right: the chanting of the holy name is bound by no rules of time or place; it must be repeated always, in purity and in impurity alike. For if death should come at such a moment, how could one then attain the auspicious remembrance of the Lord?[1]

Mahaprabhu heard this and was delighted. He announced to the devotees that Gopala was doing the work of a guru, and from that day the Vaishnavas called the young Makaradhvaja Pandita Gopala Guru[2]. Thus the Lord Himself gave him the name “Guru” because he taught others to chant the names of Krishna in every circumstance. And he earned that name by his whole life: what he taught, he himself practised — and that is the mark of a true acharya.

Abhirama's Obeisance

The boy's fame quickly spread among the Vaishnavas. Around that time, tradition says, Abhirama Thakura came to Puri to test him. Abhirama's obeisance was a fearsome trial: if the stone he bowed to was not a genuine shalagrama, a vishnu-shila, it would crack or crumble into dust. Only a pure Vaishnava could withstand his obeisance; for anyone else it could cost him his life.

The Vaishnavas grew anxious for the boy whom they all loved. Seeing their alarm, Mahaprabhu placed His foot on the boy's forehead — and in memory of this a distinctive tilaka mark is worn to this day in Gopala Guru's line. Gopala was still afraid, so the Lord took him onto His lap. In this way he received Abhirama's obeisance and came to no harm. It is also said that Gopala Guru displayed extraordinary powers.

Disciple of Vakreshvara

Gopala's guru was Vakreshvara Pandita, an intimate companion of the Lord, who in the last years of His pastimes settled permanently in Puri in order to dance in His sankirtana and serve Him (see the article on Vakreshvara Pandita). Gopala was his dear and principal disciple. His devotion to his guru was beyond description, and Vakreshvara was always pleased with him. According to the "Vakreshvara-charita," five branches issued from Vakreshvara — through Chandrashekhara, Shankararanya Acharya, Govindananda, Devananda, and Gopala Guru, whose qualities surpass all description.

Heir of Svarupa Damodara

Svarupa Damodara set down the worship of Krishna in rasa, rasopasana, in his diary, his kadacha, in two parts. The inner path he placed in the mouth of Raghunatha Dasa, the outer path in that of Vakreshvara. From Raghunatha the current reached Krishnadasa Kaviraja, who revealed the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" and the "Govinda-lilamrita." From Vakreshvara it came to Gopala Guru, who in the line of disciplic succession revealed the "Smarana-krama-paddhati." Thus Svarupa's method of worship in madhura-rasa spread along two lines: from Raghunatha to Kaviraja, and from Vakreshvara to Gopala Guru[3].

Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura writes of him more than once in the "Jaiva-dharma" (ch. 26). In Purushottama, in the house of Kashi Mishra, on the very seat of Mahaprabhu, there now sits Vakreshvara's disciple Gopala Guru Gosvami, and the teaching of Svarupa Gosvami now lives in his mouth; he knows it all by heart. Bhaktivinoda calls him the chief guru of the Sri Nimananda-sampradaya in Purushottama, a teacher of the world seated on Svarupa's gadi in Mahaprabhu's place. The science of rasa that the book's hero Vrajanatha hears from Gopala Guru's lips differs in nothing from what is set out in the "Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu" and the "Ujjvala-nilamani." Bhaktivinoda, then, saw in him a follower of Svarupa and Rupa.

When Gopala Guru took Svarupa's gadi in Mahaprabhu's place, the Gaudiya Vaishnavas who followed the path of Svarupa and Rupa welcomed it gladly, without a trace of envy. The pure Vaishnavas of his day recognised him as the chief guru of the Sri Nimananda-sampradaya. Some communities, secretly hungry for prestige, hold that a disciple who sits as acharya on his guru's gadi offends him by usurping his place. But Gopala Guru gave no occasion for such reproach, and Bhaktivinoda did not share that view. When a loving, worthy, and well-conducted disciple takes the vyasa-asana, the guru-asana, in order to serve his guru, that is genuine service to the guru: a joy to him and a blessing to the world.

Radhakanta and the Gambhira

In Nilachala, Mahaprabhu lived in the house of Kashi Mishra. The tradition of the Radhakanta Matha also tells of the Deity of that house. King Purushottama-deva, the father of Prataparudra, having defeated the king of Kanchi, brought back several Deities from there, among them Radhakanta. At first He was housed in a small temple by the north-western corner of the Chatrabhoga, Jagannatha's kitchen; later Kashi Mishra, the guru of Prataparudra, asked for Him for his own personal worship.

Kashi Mishra had no children, and he bequeathed all his property to Mahaprabhu. Mahaprabhu in turn entrusted the service of Radhakanta, together with His temple and gardens, to Gopala Guru and made him the first acharya of the Radhakanta Matha. Vakreshvara himself never sat on the gadi of that house: he remained in kirtana and dance beside the Lord. This took place on the shukla-dvadashi of the month of Magha, and ever since, on that day each year, the abhisheka of the present head of the matha is performed[4].

Since Gopala Guru's time the house of Kashi Mishra has been called the Radhakanta Matha. In Kashi Mishra's day Krishna alone was worshipped here; under Gopala Guru, Radha came to stand at

Radhakanta's left and Lalita at His right, and shri-murtis of Gauranga and Nityananda were installed as well. At the same time the temple buildings were restored and enlarged — between 1538 and 1548.

In an Orissan temple, as Bhaktivinoda explains, a veranda runs in front of the altar room, a covered paved court lies before that, and a small room in this part of the house is called a gambhira. The Gambhira in Kashi Mishra's house is the very room where Mahaprabhu sank into contemplation and where He slept. Gopala Guru kept here His wooden sandals and His quilt, sewn by Svarupa Damodara or by Jagadananda Pandita — they are worshipped to this day. Here too stands a clay water-pot from Vraja that the Lord used, and a wooden pot placed there later. On one side of the Radhakanta Matha is the temple of Radhakanta; on the other, the room where Gopala Guru used to sit, in which his shri-murti is now installed.

In Utkala most of those who belong to his line of disciples call themselves Gaudiya Vaishnavas.

Narottama in the House of Kashi Mishra

When Narottama Dasa Thakura came to Puri, Gopala Guru received him in the house of Kashi Mishra with great love. Narahari Chakravarti describes the meeting in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (8.382–392). Gopala Guru confides to his guest that he lives on only by the Lord's will, and that his heart breaks each time he sees these places. He shows him the grass mat on which the Lord sat alone in deep seclusion, and the place where He slept while Govinda massaged His feet. Here the Lord revealed a love beyond the reach even of Brahma.

Seeing the Lord's bed and seat, Narottama rolled on the ground and wept. Gopala Guru embraced him in agitation, and both cried aloud. Then, recovering himself, Gopala Guru consoled his guest, showed him all the places where the Lord had been overwhelmed by divine emotion, told him of Vakreshvara, and placed Narottama at the lotus feet of Radhakanta. So Narottama received the darshana of Gopala Guru's feet and of the Deities of the Radhakanta Matha, and from there went on to the Gundicha.

Writings

His principal work is the “Smarana-krama-paddhati,” also known as the “Seva-smarana-paddhati” or simply the “Smarana-paddhati,” that is, “the method of remembrance” of the Lord. It consists of twenty-six chapters or topics. It begins with the nature of Krishna; then come the evidence that service to Him in Vraja is rendered in sweetness, madhurya, a discussion of fear and similar feelings in His humanlike pastimes, and how He differs from the jiva. Next come the manifest and unmanifest pastimes: parakiya, the gopis' three months of separation, Krishna's return to Vraja after the slaying of Dantavakra, the eternity of the pastimes in the three dhamas, the unsurpassed pastimes of the young cowherd, and Vrindavana as Goloka. Then raganuga-bhajana in its two forms, kama-rupa and sambandha-rupa, the qualification for it, and service in the body of the sadhaka. After this, mantras and meditations: the thirty-two-syllable mantra composed of sixteen names and meditation on it according to the tantras, the ten-syllable mantra as the basis of the Gopala-mantra, the kama-gayatri, radha-tattva and the mantra of Radha, remembrance of the guru and the order of remembering the line of gurus, the gaura-mantra and gaura-gayatri. And finally the service itself: to Gaurasundara from His waking until His rest; to Radha-Govinda in the spiritual form, the siddha-deha, at the side of one's guru in the form of a sakhi, together with Lalita and the other sakhis and with Rupa-manjari; meditation on the Divine Couple, the lotus, the eight sakhis and the groups, yuthas, with their mantras, remembrance of Radha-Govinda in the thousand-petalled lotus, the ashtakala-lila, and the order of japa.

Gopala Guru opens the order of worship of Sri Chaitanya thus: rising before sunrise, having bathed and dressed, the devotee bows in turn to his guru, parama-guru, paratpara-guru, parama-preshtha-guru and the Gosvamis, then to the chief companions of Chaitanya headed by Svarupa and Rupa, then to

Chaitanya Himself, and after this, following the instructions of the guru and the Gosvamis, serves Him from His waking until His rest. This alone shows how he revered Svarupa and Rupa. Here he calls his guru the sakhi Tungavidya and the Son of Shachi the Son of Nanda: “I honour Vakreshvara Pandita — Sri Tungavidya; I honour Sri Chaitanya, the son of Shachi — Sri Nanda-nandana.” And he adds that in the age of Kali she became renowned as Vakreshvara.

The book closes with a verse saying that neither saffron robes, nor strict rules of diet, nor life in the forest, nor learned commentary, nor a vow of silence can destroy the lust born of the mind. What destroys it is even the slightest beginning of service to the feet of Govinda, who plays on the banks of the broad Yamuna.

At Vakreshvara's instruction Gopala Guru drew out the gaura-mantra and the order of worship of Gaura from many eternal sattvata-shastras and made them the treasure of the devotees. Gaurasundara is not merely a historical figure, a hero of this world: He is the beginningless, original Govinda, the cause of all causes, and therefore His name, His mantra, and the order of His worship are eternal. Those communities that oppose the gaura-mantra have only deprived themselves: Gopala Guru's paddhati is closed to them.

The “Gaura-govindarchana-paddhati” is also his. His “Smarana-paddhati” and the “Dhyanachandra-paddhati” of his disciple are well known among pure Vaishnavas. Several old manuscripts of both books have been seen, copied in the hand of Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati and gathered in Vraja-mandala. Gopala Guru's paddhati itself Bhaktivinoda received from his gadi. It was kept in various ancient mathas of Vraja, and that alone shows how the Gaudiya Vaishnavas revered it. Since it describes the methods of bhajana, the original is not usually printed, and spreading either paddhati among all is especially forbidden.

Gopala Guru also composed the “Harinamartha-nirnaya,” an explanation of the meaning of the holy name. It contains the verse “sri-chaitanya-mukhodgirna…” with which the “Sara-sangraha,” ascribed to Srila Jiva Gosvami, opens. Linked to his explanation of the maha-mantra is the account Manohara Dasa gives in the “Anuraga-valli” (8.15–30). Searching for a description of Mahaprabhu's succession, Manohara Dasa met in Vrindavana, in the kunja of Sri Jiva Gosvami, an old Vaishnava named Radhavallabha Dasa, of the family of Gopala Guru's disciples. He gave him an old manuscript of Gopala Guru's — an explanation of the Hari-nama and a determination of the sampradaya. “His seat is in Nilachala, the service of Radhakanta,” Manohara Dasa writes of him, and quotes four shlokas from that manuscript:

“Revealing the truth of Bhagavan, whose form is concentrated consciousness and bliss, He removes ignorance and its effects; therefore He is remembered as Hari. She steals the mind of Sri Krishna, She whose nature is Krishna's delight; therefore by the word ‘Hara’ (vocative ‘Hare’) Sri Radha is glorified. The master of the sole joy of bliss, Shyama, lotus-eyed, the delight of Gokula, the son of Nanda — He is called Krishna. The embodiment of the whole essence of artfulness, the presiding deity of the pastimes, He eternally delights Radhika — therefore He is called Rama.” (“Anuraga-valli,” 8.26)

Gopala Guru's writings also record the succession from Madhva — as do the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” and the “Prameya-ratnavali.” Baladeva Vidyabhushana's list of acharyas from Madhva to Chaitanya seems to have been taken from the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika,” and also from Gopala Guru's sadhana-paddhati and the works of Dhyanachandra, Chaitanya Dasa, and Manohara Dasa.

Disciples and Succession

His disciple was Dhyanachandra Gosvami, one of the important acharyas of the Gaudiya sampradaya and author of the “Dhyanachandra-paddhati.” The “Guru-pranali” — a record of the succession compiled by Sri Adikanda Dasa and found in Vraja-mandala — traces the line thus: Mahaprabhu — Vakreshvara Pandita — Gopala Guru Gosvami — Dhyanachandra Mahanta Gosvami (in the manuscript his name appears twice) — Balabhadra Mahanta — Vanamali Dasa — Prabhakara Dasa — Sadananda Dasa — Kalpataru Dasa — Paramananda Dasa — Dinabandhu Dasa — Adikanda Dasa.

The Utkala poet Govinda-deva, of Vakreshvara's circle, glorifies Vakreshvara in his poem “Sri Gaura-krishnodaya” (1680 Shaka, 1758 CE; 1.5, 18.60), yet does not mention Gopala Guru, Vakreshvara's principal disciple. Perhaps the poet was not of his branch; nor does he anywhere name his own guru (see the article on Vakreshvara Pandita).

His Passing and the Traditions about It

Growing old, Gopala Guru handed over charge of the Radhakanta Matha and the service of Radhakanta to his disciple Dhyanachandra. Soon afterwards he left his body. What follows is told by tradition. Dhyanachandra, stricken with grief, carried his guru's body to the Svarga-dvara on the seashore, where cremations were held in Puri in those days. While the disciples were there, officers of a government department barred the temple, declaring that authority had been passed to Dhyanachandra without the minister's sanction.

Hearing this, Dhyanachandra fell weeping at the feet of his guru, whose body already lay upon the funeral pyre. The prayer of his beloved disciple reached Gopala Guru: he rose from the pyre, chanting the holy names in sankirtana. The officials took fright and gave up their claim to the matha. Gopala Guru returned to the temple, made over the house to his disciple by a lawful deed, and some time later departed for good[5].

This was on the shukla-navami of the month of Kartika (in our calendar, the month of Damodara), and on that day the Gaudiya Vaishnavas honour his memory[6].

A year after his passing, tradition relates, devotees returning to Vraja from the Ratha-yatra were astonished to see him in Vrindavana, at Vamshivata: he was sitting beneath a pakur tree chanting the holy name. When Dhyanachandra learned of it, he hurried to Vrindavana, fell at his feet, and begged to be allowed to stay in Vraja, though Gopala Guru told him to return to Puri and his duties.

At last Gopala Guru said: if the separation was so unbearable, let Dhyanachandra have his image carved from neem wood, set it before the altar room of the temple, and serve it. So it was done, and his shri-murti is worshipped in the Radhakanta Matha to this day.

On the day of his passing a song about him is sung, signed with the name Narahari. The song calls him a wish-fulfilling tree for the devotees, recalls Makaradhvaja Pandita, whom the Lord named Gopala; it says that he was always intoxicated with his own songs, incomparable and captivating every heart; that no one was as merciful as he, that all praised him, and that he made everyone worthy of divine love. The poet laments that, because of his sins, he alone has been left without prema.

Manjumedhika

Gopala Guru has always been honoured by the whole Gaudiya Vaishnava community. In calling his guru Tungavidya and the Son of Shachi the Son of Nanda, he preached nothing contrary to siddhanta — nothing like the later gaura-nagari teaching that grew up in Shrikhanda: the teaching of Svarupa and Rupa stood firm in his mouth. His paddhati shows that his worship of Gaura as the Son of Nanda and of the guru as a sakhi remains within the siddhanta of Svarupa and Rupa.

Who he is in the eternal pastimes is told by the “Guru-pranali” of his line — both Adikanda Dasa's manuscript and the edition of the Radhakanta Matha. Vakreshvara in his perfected form is Tungavidya. She has eight sakhis: Manjumedha, Sumadhura, Sumadhya, Madhurekshana, Tanumadhya, Madhusudha, Gunachuda, and Varangana. “The magnanimous Gopala Guru is her maidservant, her anugopi; by Chaitanya's mercy his siddha name is Manjumedhika.” Thus in Vraja he is the sakhi Manjumedha, the maidservant of Tungavidya[7].

1. So teaches the Lord Himself: “The chanting of Your names grants all perfection and is bound by no rules of time or place: they may be chanted even while eating or resting” (CC, Antya 20.18; cf. “Shikshashtaka,” 2). Through the boy's lips the Lord's own teaching was voiced.

2. Other accounts tell of the name differently. The song about Gopala Guru says that the boy was explaining a certain rule of devotion to another child, and the Lord in ecstasy told everyone, “From today I shall call Gopala ‘guru’” — and the devotees wept with joy to see His mercy. According to a third account, the Lord lovingly called him “guru” in jest, and so the name stayed with him.

3. According to one of the biographies, Gopala Guru was instructed in the science of rasa under the guidance of Svarupa Damodara and Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami and became expert in its principles; elsewhere he is even called a disciple of Svarupa Damodara — probably in the sense of succession, since his guru was Vakreshvara.

4. Accounts of this differ. According to one biography, after the Lord this place passed to Vakreshvara, and the Deity of Radhakanta was installed only in Gopala Guru's time; some say that Gopala Guru himself founded the Radhakanta Matha. According to another, he remained in Kashi Mishra's house after Vakreshvara's passing and then installed Radha-Kanta; yet elsewhere in that same book it is Vakreshvara himself who installs Radha-Kanta.

5. In another telling of the same tradition, the matha was closed by the king's men, and Gopala Guru, having settled the matter at the temple, returned to the cremation ground; and even after that he appeared in Vrindavana, where devotees saw him engaged in service.

6. The day of his passing is not marked in our calendar.

7. According to one of the biographies, “in the opinion of some,” Gopala Guru is Tungavidya-sakhi herself. But both his own paddhati and the “Guru-pranali” identify Tungavidya as Vakreshvara; apparently the guru's identity has here been transferred to the disciple. In the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (GGD 163) Tungavidya is identified as Prabodhananda Sarasvati.